

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Consulting English



Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For management consultants, strategy consultants, implementation consultants, analysts, engagement managers, client partners, internal consultants, and advisory teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Discovery discussion

02 Hypothesis review

03 A focused data request

04 Executive storyline

05 An additional workstream

06 Difficult client feedback

07 Implementation ownership

08 Final steering committee

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Discovery discussion

Consultants clarify a client's initial problem statement.

Roles: Engagement manager / Client operations director

Engagement manager: You described the problem as low productivity. Where does it show up in the workflow?

Client operations director: Orders wait between review and approval, but staff utilization looks high.

Engagement manager: Then we should examine queue time and rework, not assume people need to work faster.

Client operations director: We can provide process records and introduce the approval teams.

Engagement manager: I'll frame the diagnostic questions and agree on the scope of the first analysis.

Client operations director: Please distinguish what you know from the hypotheses you're testing in the kickoff materials.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "You described the problem as low productivity. Where does it show up in the workflow?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Hypothesis review

A consulting team tests an attractive explanation.

Roles: Partner / Consultant

Partner: Your slide says pricing is the reason for the sales decline. What evidence rules out other drivers?

Consultant: None yet. It's our working hypothesis, based on three customer interviews.

Partner: Then label it that way and test volume, mix, distribution, and competitor changes too.

Consultant: I'll update the issue tree and identify the data required for each branch.

Partner: Prioritize the questions that could change the recommendation.

Consultant: I'll bring a revised analysis plan with the assumptions and evidence gaps visible.

Notice the professional language

issue tree - A structured breakdown of a question into smaller issues for analysis.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

A focused data request

A consultant reduces the burden on a client team.

Roles: Consultant / Client finance lead

Consultant: Our initial request was too broad. For the margin bridge, we need monthly product-level revenue, volume, and cost.

Client finance lead: That's manageable. Do you need customer names?

Consultant: No. An approved aggregate extract should be sufficient for this question.

Client finance lead: I'll confirm definitions and any reporting changes across the period.

Consultant: I'll send a field list and a sample layout for review.

Client finance lead: Good. We'll agree on the extract before asking the data team to build it.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "That's manageable. Do you need customer names?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Executive storyline

A consultant revises a dense presentation.

Roles: Engagement manager / Consultant

Engagement manager: What's the decision this deck asks the executive team to make?

Consultant: Whether to pilot a different approval process in two regions.

Engagement manager: Lead with that recommendation, then the evidence, cost, risks, and pilot criteria.

Consultant: I'll move detailed interview notes into the appendix and retain the limitations in the main story.

Engagement manager: Make the implementation owner and decision timing explicit.

Consultant: I'll revise the opening so the audience can understand the proposal before reading the supporting analysis.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What's the decision this deck asks the executive team to make?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

An additional workstream

A client requests work beyond the agreed engagement.

Roles: Client sponsor / Engagement manager

Client sponsor: Could you also redesign our incentive scheme before the final readout?

Engagement manager: That would add a distinct workstream. Let's assess the effort and implications for the agreed scope.

Client sponsor: Could we replace one of the current deliverables?

Engagement manager: Yes, we can compare that option with an extension and bring the tradeoffs for approval.

Client sponsor: I'll explain which outcome now has priority.

Engagement manager: I'll prepare a written change proposal before assigning the additional work.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Could you also redesign our incentive scheme before the final readout?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Difficult client feedback

A consultant responds to criticism of an interim finding.

Roles: Client director / Consultant

Client director: Your analysis misses how our local teams actually operate.

Consultant: Please show me where the process description differs from practice. I want to correct that before drawing conclusions.

Client director: Approval authority varies by region, but your chart assumes one model.

Consultant: That's material. I'll separate the regional models and test whether the comparison still holds.

Client director: Include regional leads in the validation discussion.

Consultant: I will. The next version will state what changed and how it affects the finding.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Your analysis misses how our local teams actually operate." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Implementation ownership

A consulting team prepares to transfer a plan.

Roles: Implementation consultant / Client workstream lead

Implementation consultant: Which team will own the process after the pilot ends?

Client workstream lead: Operations, but we haven't confirmed capacity for the new review step.

Implementation consultant: Then ownership is proposed, not accepted. Let's resolve responsibilities and workload before handover.

Client workstream lead: I'll bring the operating model to the department heads.

Implementation consultant: I'll provide the process documentation, training plan, and unresolved decisions.

Client workstream lead: We'll confirm acceptance criteria and record any support needed during the transition.

Notice the professional language

operating model - How work is organized across people, process, technology, governance, and metrics.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Final steering committee

A consultant clarifies what a pilot established.

Roles: Project sponsor / Consulting lead

Project sponsor: Can the final report say the pilot proves the new model will work company-wide?

Consulting lead: It supports the model in the tested locations. Broader rollout still carries assumptions about volume and local processes.

Project sponsor: What decision can we reasonably make now?

Consulting lead: Whether to expand in stages with defined measures and review points.

Project sponsor: Show the evidence for that recommendation and the conditions that would change it.

Consulting lead: I'll include the limitations, resource needs, and a clear decision request in the final readout.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Can the final report say the pilot proves the new model will work company-wide?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Client Discovery and Problem Definition

SHARED CASE

A client requests a benchmarking study but actually needs to decide whether to centralize a service.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

What decision will the benchmark help you make? If the question is centralization, we should examine the criteria and constraints first, then decide which external comparisons would be useful.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Hypotheses and Issue Trees

SHARED CASE

A team believes customer churn is caused by price but has not examined service experience or competitor changes.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

Price is one hypothesis, not an established explanation. I'll structure the work around the main alternatives and identify the evidence that would support or weaken each one.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Data Requests and Client Burden

SHARED CASE

A client receives a 40-item data request with one deadline. Only six items are needed for the first analysis.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we prioritize the six items needed for the first analysis and agree on their owners? I'll explain their purpose and propose later dates for the remaining requests to reduce unnecessary burden.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

SHARED CASE

A presentation has twelve charts and no clear recommendation. The audience must decide whether to pilot a new process.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'll lead with the pilot recommendation and the decision required, then use the strongest evidence and its limitations to support it. The remaining charts can answer follow-up questions.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Scope Management and Change Requests

SHARED CASE

A client requests a second market study halfway through an engagement. The existing schedule covers only the original market.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Cover this until after your first attempt

We can assess the additional market as a scope change. Would you prefer to extend the schedule, add resources, or reprioritize the original work? I'll prepare the implications for discussion.

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Difficult Client Feedback

SHARED CASE

A client says a recommendation ignores a staffing constraint that the team missed in discovery.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Cover this until after your first attempt

You're right that the recommendation does not account for that staffing constraint. Let's confirm its effect and revise the options. I'll make the changed assumption explicit in the next version.

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Implementation and Change Management

SHARED CASE

Managers are expected to adopt a new process but have not received training or time to practice.

Role A | Responding professional

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Useful expressions

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The rollout asks managers to change their work without enough preparation. Could we add role-specific training and a short practice period, then check where adoption is difficult?

Second round

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Steering Committees and Final Readouts

SHARED CASE

A steering group agrees on the problem but is split between two options. The presentation time is almost over.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Let's pause the slides and compare the two options against the agreed criteria. Then we can record the decision, or the precise unresolved question and who will resolve it by when.

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Lesson conversations and speaking practice

The following sections match 05 and 06 on the industry webpage and in the learner workbook. Each lesson has three ten-turn conversations and two bounded speaking scenarios. These are original fictional teaching scripts, not transcripts of real people.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Benchmarking for which decision?

The lesson's client asks for benchmarking but needs to decide whether to centralize a service.

01 • Engagement manager: Before we scope the benchmarking study, could you clarify which decision the findings need to support?

02 • Client service director: We need to decide whether to centralize the service. Benchmarking is the approach we initially had in mind.

03 • Engagement manager: Then the decision question concerns centralization, rather than simply how we compare with other organizations.

04 • Client service director: Yes. Would you still use benchmarking, or are you suggesting we abandon the request?

05 • Engagement manager: It may contribute evidence, but discovery should first establish the problem and the criteria for that decision.

06 • Client service director: What do you need clarified before proposing the study's scope and stakeholder discussions?

07 • Engagement manager: Which service is in scope, what problem centralization should address, and who will make the decision.

08 • Client service director: Those need explicit answers. We shouldn't assume our initial request contains an agreed problem statement.

09 • Engagement manager: Exactly. I'll frame those questions for our next discussion without treating centralization as the preferred outcome.

10 • Client service director: Good. Let's define the decision before committing to a research method or a recommendation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A dashboard request conceals a handover problem

Separate fictional case: a client asks for a new dashboard because orders repeatedly wait between sales and operations; the reason for the waiting is unknown.

01 • Discovery consultant: You requested a dashboard because orders wait between sales and operations. What decision should it support?

02 • Client operations lead: We want fewer stalled orders, but we haven't specified who would act on the information.

03 • Discovery consultant: Could we clarify the handover problem before assuming a new display is the required solution?

04 • Client operations lead: Yes. We know orders wait, but we don't yet know whether missing information or unclear ownership causes it.

05 • Discovery consultant: Which stakeholders can explain what they receive, what they need, and when they accept responsibility?

06 • Client operations lead: Sales and operations both need to contribute. I can arrange a joint discovery conversation.

07 • Discovery consultant: Good. We should not write a problem statement that already assumes the dashboard will solve the issue.

08 • Client operations lead: Then the initial question is how to reduce waiting at the handover, with the solution still open.

09 • Discovery consultant: Exactly. We'll clarify the workflow and desired result before recommending a particular tool.

10 • Client operations lead: I'll invite the relevant owners and make clear that we're defining the problem, not approving a dashboard build.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Cost reduction or more reliable delivery?

Separate fictional case: a sponsor asks for efficiency improvements, while a project brief mentions both lower cost and more reliable delivery without ranking them.

01 • Consulting lead: The brief uses efficiency, but lists lower cost and more reliable delivery. Which objective drives the decision?

02 • Client sponsor: We haven't ranked them. Different stakeholders may be using efficiency to mean different things.

03 • Consulting lead: Could we clarify what tradeoff you would consider acceptable before we define the problem statement?

04 • Client sponsor: Yes. I don't want the team to recommend a cost reduction that silently weakens delivery reliability.

05 • Consulting lead: Then both objectives need explicit definitions, and we should identify who can resolve a conflict between them.

06 • Client sponsor: I can convene the relevant managers, but I should not assume they all share my priorities.

07 • Consulting lead: Good. Discovery should surface those differences rather than translate an ambiguous word into a single assumed target.

08 • Client sponsor: Would you ask each manager what decision they need to make and what evidence would help?

09 • Consulting lead: Exactly. We'll compare their answers and bring unresolved priorities back for an explicit discussion.

10 • Client sponsor: Let's do that before agreeing a scope that measures the wrong version of efficiency.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Client Discovery and Problem Definition

A client requests a benchmarking study but actually needs to decide whether to centralize a service.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: What decision will the benchmark help you make? If the question is centralization, we should examine the criteria and constraints first, then decide which external comparisons would be useful.

Scenario 2 | A survey request with no decision owner

A fictional client requests an employee survey about office space, but has not identified whether the decision concerns desk allocation, attendance arrangements, or a lease. No decision owner is named. Hold a discovery call.

Role A: You are the consultant. Clarify the decision and its owner before discussing survey questions.

Role B: You are the client coordinator. Acknowledge the missing scope and identify whom you must consult.

Possible opening: Could you clarify which office-space decision this survey needs to support?

Success checks

- Separate the requested research method from the decision question.
- Keep the decision scope and owner explicitly unresolved.
- Agree the clarification needed before designing the research.

Add a complication: The coordinator wants to send a survey immediately to show progress.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Price is a hypothesis, not the whole issue tree

The lesson's team attributes churn to price without examining service experience or competitor changes.

01 • Workstream lead: The team thinks price is driving churn, but we haven't examined service experience or competitor changes.

02 • Engagement manager: Then price belongs in the issue tree as a hypothesis, not as an established conclusion.

03 • Workstream lead: Could we organize the evidence plan around price first because that explanation feels most plausible?

04 • Engagement manager: We can prioritize questions, but the plan must still test alternatives rather than only seek supporting examples.

05 • Workstream lead: I'll separate the price, service-experience, and competitor questions so the workstream doesn't overlook them.

06 • Engagement manager: Good. What will you say if the client asks whether we have already found the churn cause?

07 • Workstream lead: We have a price hypothesis, while other explanations remain unexamined. Attribution is not established.

08 • Engagement manager: Exactly. Avoid making the wording more certain simply because the slide needs a short title.

09 • Workstream lead: I'll show what evidence each branch requires and flag any data we cannot obtain.

10 • Engagement manager: Then our next discussion can compare findings across explanations rather than defend the first idea.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Late deliveries and a recent staffing change

Separate fictional case: delivery delays rose after a staffing change; order mix and supplier performance have not been examined.

01 • Operations consultant: Delays rose after the staffing change. That timing suggests a question, but doesn't establish the cause.

02 • Client project lead: Our managers already blame the new staffing model. How should the analysis respond to their view?

03 • Operations consultant: Treat it as a hypothesis and examine alternative explanations, including order mix and supplier performance.

04 • Client project lead: Would that look like avoiding the staffing issue rather than testing it directly?

05 • Operations consultant: No. A balanced evidence plan tests the staffing explanation alongside other plausible contributors.

06 • Client project lead: Then the issue tree should distinguish observed delay growth from the possible reasons beneath it.

07 • Operations consultant: Exactly. We should also define the period and measure consistently before comparing results.

08 • Client project lead: I'll ask the managers for their supporting observations without recording their belief as a verified finding.

09 • Operations consultant: Good. Each workstream can report evidence, gaps, and contradictory examples rather than only confirm expectations.

10 • Client project lead: Let's bring that structure to the next meeting and keep the causal conclusion open.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

One interview does not close a branch

Separate fictional case: one manager says customer onboarding delays never involve approvals; the team has not reviewed approval records or other interviews.

01 • Analyst: One manager said approvals never delay onboarding. Should I remove that branch from the issue tree?

02 • Case team leader: Not on one interview alone. It is a stakeholder account, not a complete test of the hypothesis.

03 • Analyst: Then I should record the statement and identify what approval evidence would help assess it.

04 • Case team leader: Yes. We need relevant records and other perspectives before treating the branch as ruled out.

05 • Analyst: Could the manager's account still guide which cases we examine first, without deciding the answer?

06 • Case team leader: Certainly. Interviews can shape an evidence plan while remaining distinct from verified process findings.

07 • Analyst: I'll avoid writing no approval delays on the slide because that overstates the source.

08 • Case team leader: Use a precise label: one interview reported no approval delays; records have not yet been examined.

09 • Analyst: That preserves the useful observation and the uncertainty. I'll plan a targeted check rather than drop the question.

10 • Case team leader: Good. We'll update the hypothesis when the evidence warrants it, not when the first interview ends.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Hypotheses and Issue Trees

A team believes customer churn is caused by price but has not examined service experience or competitor changes.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: Price is one hypothesis, not an established explanation. I'll structure the work around the main alternatives and identify the evidence that would support or weaken each one.

Scenario 2 | A branch with no possible disproof

A fictional team's hypothesis says customers leave because they dislike something. It does not identify a specific factor or evidence that could contradict it. Discuss how to make the hypothesis testable without inventing the cause.

Role A: You are the workstream lead. Ask for a specific proposed explanation and an evidence test.

Role B: You are the analyst. Refine the question while keeping alternative explanations open.

Possible opening: This hypothesis is too broad to test; which specific factor do we think may affect departures?

Success checks

- Distinguish a broad label from a testable explanation.
- Ask what evidence could support or weaken the hypothesis.
- Agree a focused evidence question without declaring a cause.

Add a complication: A colleague says any negative customer comment proves the hypothesis.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Six items first, not forty at once

Separate fictional extension of the lesson: a forty-item request is due Friday. The first analysis needs January-March order dates, completion dates, service types, status codes, team identifiers, and a field dictionary to compare turnaround by service. Other items can be deferred by agreement.

01 • Engagement manager: Could you provide those six January-March items first, so we can compare turnaround by service before receiving everything?

02 • Client data coordinator: Our owner can prepare the dates, types, statuses, and team identifiers by Friday, but the dictionary needs Monday.

03 • Engagement manager: Could we receive the five available fields Friday and the dictionary Monday, with all remaining items deferred pending a separate schedule?

04 • Client data coordinator: Yes, but you must not interpret unfamiliar codes before the dictionary arrives. Some labels are ambiguous.

05 • Engagement manager: Agreed. We can check file structure Friday and wait until Monday to interpret the coded fields.

06 • Client data coordinator: Please use our approved secure transfer folder. No customer names are needed for this comparison.

07 • Engagement manager: Understood. Are you coordinating delivery with the data owner and flagging any availability change?

08 • Client data coordinator: Yes. I will confirm the staged request with the owner today.

09 • Engagement manager: Then five fields Friday, dictionary Monday, and a separately agreed schedule for the remaining thirty-four items.

10 • Client data coordinator: Correct. That gives us a manageable request with clear priorities and confidentiality boundaries.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A sample extract before a large pull

Separate fictional case: a consultant needs two years of tickets for a resolution-time study. First, ten synthetic examples representing January 2026 are requested with ticket ID, opened time, resolved time, status code, and a code dictionary. This sample will check structure and meaning, not measure performance.

01 • Consulting analyst: Could you provide ten synthetic January examples with the specified fields and code dictionary to validate structure before the two-year extract?

02 • Client reporting lead: Yes. Do you need customer names or message text as well?

03 • Consulting analyst: No. Ticket ID, opened time, resolved time, status code, and the dictionary are sufficient for this initial check.

04 • Client reporting lead: Our export owner can prepare the examples by Thursday. Would that fit your review?

05 • Consulting analyst: Thursday works. Please identify the timestamp time zone and show how unresolved tickets appear, rather than filling missing resolution times.

06 • Client reporting lead: Understood. The synthetic sample will illustrate those cases without exposing customer information.

07 • Consulting analyst: Could you confirm the owner and delivery route so we can arrange the review?

08 • Client reporting lead: I will coordinate delivery through the approved project folder and flag any delay.

09 • Consulting analyst: Thank you. We will validate field meanings, not calculate real resolution performance from synthetic examples.

10 • Client reporting lead: Agreed. After that check, we can discuss availability and timing for the larger authorized extract.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An unavailable field should not become a guess

Separate fictional case: a client can provide monthly totals but cannot currently export transaction-level timestamps requested for a cycle-time analysis.

01 • Workstream consultant: You can provide monthly totals, but the requested transaction timestamps are unavailable. Could you confirm the export limitation?

02 • Client systems manager: Yes. We have the totals, but we haven't established a way to extract the detailed timestamps.

03 • Workstream consultant: Thank you. Please don't estimate transaction times to fill the requested field; that would change the analysis basis.

04 • Client systems manager: Could the team use monthly totals instead, so we can meet the original deadline?

05 • Workstream consultant: They may support a different question, but they don't substitute for individual cycle-time measurements.

06 • Client systems manager: Then we need to discuss whether to change the analysis or investigate another authorized source.

07 • Workstream consultant: Exactly. Could you identify who can assess another source and estimate the work involved?

08 • Client systems manager: I'll ask the system owner and return with availability, rather than promise a detailed extract now.

09 • Workstream consultant: I'll explain the impact to the engagement lead and keep the missing evidence visible.

10 • Client systems manager: That gives us a specific next request without creating data that the system hasn't supplied.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Data Requests and Client Burden

A client receives a 40-item data request with one deadline. Only six items are needed for the first analysis.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could we prioritize the six items needed for the first analysis and agree on their owners? I'll explain their purpose and propose later dates for the remaining requests to reduce unnecessary burden.

Scenario 2 | A data owner is on leave

A fictional project's requested staffing extract belongs to an analyst who is on leave. No substitute owner or delivery date is confirmed. The first workshop can use an existing aggregate report, but its limitations must be explained. Agree a proportionate request.

Role A: You are the consultant. Ask for an authorized substitute or realistic availability check.

Role B: You are the client coordinator. Offer the aggregate report without claiming it replaces all requested detail.

Possible opening: Could you help identify an authorized owner for the extract, or confirm when the original owner can respond?

Success checks

- Request an appropriate owner without bypassing access arrangements.
- Explain what the aggregate report can and cannot support.
- Agree a realistic follow-up rather than invent a delivery commitment.

Add a complication: The consultant's colleague wants to pressure an unrelated employee to access the data.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Twelve charts and no decision ask

The lesson's presentation contains twelve charts but no clear recommendation; executives must decide whether to pilot a new process.

01 • Presentation reviewer: We have twelve charts, but what decision are we asking the executives to make about the pilot?

02 • Workstream lead: Whether to pilot the new process. The deck describes findings without making that decision ask explicit.

03 • Presentation reviewer: Then the storyline needs to connect evidence to a recommendation, not simply display all the analysis.

04 • Workstream lead: Could you explain the difference between a recommendation and the decision ask in this context?

05 • Presentation reviewer: The recommendation proposes action; the decision ask identifies what the audience must authorize or resolve.

06 • Workstream lead: So a chart title describes a result, while its so what explains why that result matters for the pilot.

07 • Presentation reviewer: Exactly. We still need to qualify any conclusion that the charts don't fully support.

08 • Workstream lead: I'll organize the spoken readout around the pilot question and keep detailed charts available for follow-up.

09 • Presentation reviewer: Good. Don't invent an approval recommendation before the evidence and remaining constraints have been considered.

10 • Workstream lead: I'll make the choice and open questions clear, then verify that the proposed storyline matches the analysis.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A finding is not yet a recommendation

Separate fictional case: a process study finds duplicate entry in two systems, but implementation costs and system constraints have not been assessed.

01 • Senior consultant: The finding is duplicate entry across two systems. Your slide recommends immediate automation, but feasibility hasn't been assessed.

02 • Analyst: I thought the recommendation was simply the practical version of the finding. What distinction am I missing?

03 • Senior consultant: The finding describes observed work. A recommendation proposes action and needs support about consequences and constraints.

04 • Analyst: Then the so what can identify possible avoidable effort without claiming automation is already the right solution.

05 • Senior consultant: Correct. We haven't assessed implementation cost or system constraints, so the next decision may concern further evaluation.

06 • Analyst: Could the decision ask be to authorize a feasibility assessment, provided the engagement lead agrees that's appropriate?

07 • Senior consultant: Yes, as a proposed next step. Label it clearly rather than imply executives have already approved automation.

08 • Analyst: I'll separate observed duplication, its possible significance, and the remaining feasibility questions in the storyline.

09 • Senior consultant: That clarifies the presentation and avoids a jump from evidence to unsupported action.

10 • Analyst: I'll bring the revised logic for review before changing the executive recommendation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A headline that hides the tradeoff

Separate fictional case: two service options are being compared; A has a shorter stated rollout and B a lower quoted setup fee, while recurring costs remain unreviewed.

01 • Engagement director: Your headline says option A is best, but the analysis only shows a shorter stated rollout.

02 • Consultant: Option B has a lower setup fee. I left that detail in a supporting chart.

03 • Engagement director: Then the storyline hides a material tradeoff. Best needs criteria, not just a preferred feature.

04 • Consultant: Would a clearer executive synthesis say A is faster to roll out, while B costs less to set up?

05 • Engagement director: Yes, with the stated basis. Recurring costs remain unreviewed, so don't call B cheaper overall.

06 • Consultant: The recommendation should explain which priority it serves and what the decision maker gives up.

07 • Engagement director: Exactly. The decision ask should then identify the choice or additional evidence needed.

08 • Consultant: I'll keep the unknown recurring costs next to the comparison rather than hide them in an appendix.

09 • Engagement director: Good. A concise story can still preserve uncertainty and the weaker side of a proposal.

10 • Consultant: I'll revise the spoken summary so executives hear the contrast before discussing a preferred option.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

A presentation has twelve charts and no clear recommendation. The audience must decide whether to pilot a new process.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: I'll lead with the pilot recommendation and the decision required, then use the strongest evidence and its limitations to support it. The remaining charts can answer follow-up questions.

Scenario 2 | An appendix becomes the opening

A fictional readout opens with ten minutes of method detail, leaving no time to discuss a limited pilot. A measured trial of ten handovers at one branch reduced median handover time from twelve minutes to nine; no other branch or live rollout has been tested. Discuss a clearer spoken order using this finding and its limited scope.

Role A: You are the engagement lead. Ask for the decision question, central finding, and main limitation first.

Role B: You are the analyst. Explain where the method detail can support questions rather than obscure the decision.

Possible opening: Let's begin with the pilot decision and the main finding, then use the method detail to support questions.

Success checks

- Explain the difference between sequencing evidence and concealing it.
- Keep the main limitation in the opening summary.
- Agree a clear storyline leading to the decision ask.

Add a complication: The analyst believes moving detail later means hiding it.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A second market changes the engagement

The lesson's client requests a second market study midway through an engagement scoped and scheduled for one market.

01 • Client sponsor: Could you add a second market study? We'd like it included in the current engagement readout.

02 • Engagement manager: We can assess that change request, but the current schedule and statement of work cover only the original market.

03 • Client sponsor: Could the team work faster so the additional scope doesn't affect either timing or cost?

04 • Engagement manager: I can't assume that. We need to assess the extra work and discuss an explicit tradeoff.

05 • Client sponsor: What options could we consider without committing to an unreviewed extension right now?

06 • Engagement manager: We could assess a later second study or a revised first-phase scope, subject to agreement.

07 • Client sponsor: Please show what each option includes and what would be deferred rather than just presenting a new fee.

08 • Engagement manager: Agreed. Any schedule or scope change needs the appropriate approval before the team treats it as committed.

09 • Client sponsor: I'll keep the request as a proposal while you estimate the implications for our decision needs.

10 • Engagement manager: I'll return with bounded alternatives and maintain the original plan until a change is agreed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An extra workshop without extra preparation time

Separate fictional case: a consulting engagement includes one leadership workshop; the client asks for a separate frontline workshop before the same readout, with no additional capacity confirmed.

01 • Client project lead: Could you add a frontline workshop before the readout? The scope currently includes only the leadership session.

02 • Consulting manager: We can discuss it. A different audience may require different preparation, so it isn't simply another calendar invitation.

03 • Client project lead: Would using the same materials let you deliver both without changing the agreed schedule?

04 • Consulting manager: Possibly, but we'd need to assess whether those materials answer the frontline group's needs appropriately.

05 • Client project lead: Could we reduce the leadership session to make room, rather than add unplanned work?

06 • Consulting manager: That's an option to review, provided the sponsor accepts what the shorter session would no longer cover.

07 • Client project lead: Please compare a scope swap with a later additional workshop and make the conditions visible.

08 • Consulting manager: I will. Neither option is confirmed until we check preparation effort and obtain the relevant agreement.

09 • Client project lead: I'll avoid promising the frontline team a date until that change request is settled.

10 • Consulting manager: Thank you. We'll propose a useful tradeoff instead of silently expanding the statement of work.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Translation for a new audience

Separate fictional case: a final report is scoped in English; the client requests a second-language presentation, but translation review and presenter availability are unassessed.

01 • Client communications lead: Could the final presentation also be delivered in another language? Our current scope specifies English only.

02 • Engagement director: We can assess the request, but translation review and suitable presenter availability haven't been established.

03 • Client communications lead: Could you translate the slides automatically and keep the original delivery date without further review?

04 • Engagement director: I wouldn't promise that. The translated meaning and delivery arrangement need checking, especially for qualified findings.

05 • Client communications lead: Then what bounded alternative could help us discuss the results with that audience sooner?

06 • Engagement director: We could assess a translated summary or a later interpreted discussion, with scope and review requirements explicit.

07 • Client communications lead: Please show the tradeoff between the amount of material and the preparation time each option needs.

08 • Engagement director: Agreed. We'll keep the existing deliverable unchanged unless the authorized change request is approved.

09 • Client communications lead: I'll clarify the audience's actual need before we select one of those alternatives.

10 • Engagement director: That will help us propose a proportionate change without promising unverified timing or language quality.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Scope Management and Change Requests

A client requests a second market study halfway through an engagement. The existing schedule covers only the original market.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Second round: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Model for scenario 1: We can assess the additional market as a scope change. Would you prefer to extend the schedule, add resources, or reprioritize the original work? I'll prepare the implications for discussion.

Scenario 2 | A requested update after final handover

A fictional engagement has handed over its final analysis. The client now requests monthly refreshes, which were not included in the statement of work. Data access and refresh effort are unknown. Discuss a bounded follow-on option.

Role A: You are the engagement manager. Clarify frequency and purpose, then propose an assessment of the additional service.

Role B: You are the client sponsor. Discuss whether one later update could meet the immediate need.

Possible opening: Monthly refreshes would be additional work; could we clarify the decision each update needs to support?

Success checks

- Separate the completed engagement from proposed ongoing work.
- Offer a specific alternative with conditions.
- Avoid committing cost, timing, or access before assessment and agreement.

Add a complication: The sponsor assumes final handover includes indefinite ongoing support.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The staffing constraint we missed

The lesson's client says the recommendation overlooks a staffing constraint missed during discovery.

01 • Client operations director: Your recommendation ignores our staffing constraint. We raised an operational concern that the discovery work didn't capture.

02 • Engagement lead: You're right that the recommendation doesn't account for it. We need to correct that assumption before presenting implementation as feasible.

03 • Client operations director: I don't want another polished explanation that leaves the actual staffing problem unchanged.

04 • Engagement lead: Understood. Could we confirm the constraint precisely, then reassess how it affects the recommendation?

05 • Client operations director: Yes, but please acknowledge that the current proposal isn't ready simply because the slides are finished.

06 • Engagement lead: Agreed. Completion of the deck doesn't establish implementation readiness or stakeholder buy-in.

07 • Client operations director: Will the next iteration show what changed because of the constraint, rather than just mention it in a footnote?

08 • Engagement lead: Yes. We'll make the revised assumption and its implications visible, while identifying anything that still needs validation.

09 • Client operations director: That would make the correction useful. Let's review the operational requirement before choosing an alternative.

10 • Engagement lead: I'll arrange that review and avoid defending the original recommendation as if its missing assumption were immaterial.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A recommendation sounded like a decision

Separate fictional case: a consulting presentation called a proposed role change the new operating arrangement; the client has not approved it.

01 • Client HR lead: Your presentation made the role change sound decided. Staff are asking when the new arrangement begins.

02 • Consulting manager: Our wording was too definite. It is a recommendation for review, not an approved client decision.

03 • Client HR lead: Please correct that distinction before another team hears the same message from your slides.

04 • Consulting manager: I will. I'll state that approval is pending and remove wording that implies an implementation commitment.

05 • Client HR lead: Does the correction also recognize that we haven't assessed the staffing implications with the affected managers?

06 • Consulting manager: Yes. That is an implementation constraint and a stakeholder discussion still needed, not a completed step.

07 • Client HR lead: I appreciate the correction, but I don't want the team to infer that consultation guarantees acceptance.

08 • Consulting manager: Understood. Consultation informs the decision; it doesn't establish buy-in or predetermine the outcome.

09 • Client HR lead: Let's agree the corrected explanation before it goes into the next readout.

10 • Consulting manager: I'll bring that iteration for review and keep the proposal's status explicit throughout the presentation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An interview summary omitted the exception

Separate fictional case: a client's interview described a standard approval route and an exception for urgent repairs; the consulting summary included only the standard route.

01 • Client maintenance lead: Your summary left out the urgent-repair exception I described. It makes our process look more rigid than it is.

02 • Consulting analyst: You're right. I summarized the standard route and omitted the exception, which changes the interpretation.

03 • Client maintenance lead: Will you remove the finding that every repair waits for the same approval sequence?

04 • Consulting analyst: I'll correct that unsupported statement and check the exception's scope before revising the analysis.

05 • Client maintenance lead: Please don't swing to the opposite assumption that every urgent repair bypasses all approvals.

06 • Consulting analyst: Agreed. Your explanation establishes an exception exists, not every detail of how it operates.

07 • Client maintenance lead: I can review a corrected process summary with you so the distinction is accurately represented.

08 • Consulting analyst: Thank you. I'll separate the standard route, the stated exception, and any implementation question that remains open.

09 • Client maintenance lead: That will help the next iteration reflect the actual constraint rather than a simplified version.

10 • Consulting analyst: I'll also check which recommendations relied on the incomplete summary and identify the implications of the correction.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Difficult Client Feedback

A client says a recommendation ignores a staffing constraint that the team missed in discovery.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Second round: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Model for scenario 1: You're right that the recommendation does not account for that staffing constraint. Let's confirm its effect and revise the options. I'll make the changed assumption explicit in the next version.

Scenario 2 | An unavailable system was assumed available

A fictional recommendation assumes the client can use a reporting tool, but the client says access has not been approved. The analysis team never checked this assumption. Practice acknowledging the omission and planning a revised feasibility discussion.

Role A: You are the consulting lead. Own the unchecked assumption and explain what must change in the recommendation's status.

Role B: You are the client project manager. Ask for alternatives without committing to an unreviewed tool purchase.

Possible opening: We assumed access to the reporting tool without confirming it, so the current recommendation needs reassessment.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the specific unchecked assumption.
- Avoid making the client responsible for validating an unsupported recommendation after the fact.
- Agree a revised feasibility review with remaining unknowns explicit.

Add a complication: A consultant suggests the client simply buy access to preserve the original recommendation.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Adoption needs practice, not just an announcement

The lesson's managers are expected to adopt a new process without training or practice time.

01 • Change consultant: Managers are expected to adopt the new process, but they haven't received training or time to practice.

02 • Client transformation lead: We sent the announcement. Shouldn't that be enough for managers to begin following the operating model?

03 • Change consultant: An announcement communicates the change; it doesn't show that people can carry out the new steps.

04 • Client transformation lead: Then the feedback should concern the missing preparation, not accuse managers of resisting adoption.

05 • Change consultant: Exactly. Describe the observed gap, its effect on readiness, and a practical opportunity for supported practice.

06 • Client transformation lead: Could we ask managers to walk through one typical case and identify unclear decision rights?

07 • Change consultant: Yes. That would surface where they need guidance about who can decide or approve an action.

08 • Client transformation lead: I'll arrange the preparation discussion without treating attendance as proof of successful adoption.

09 • Change consultant: Good. Follow-up observation should check how the process is used, not merely whether the message was sent.

10 • Client transformation lead: We'll use that evidence to refine support and distinguish planned change management from demonstrated readiness.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A manager keeps using the old approval route

Separate fictional case: in a practice session, a manager routes a request through the old approval sequence; the new decision-rights guide is available but has not been explained.

01 • Implementation coach: During practice, the request followed the old approval route even though the new guide shows a different sequence.

02 • Client change lead: Should we report that as resistance, or first examine whether the manager understood the revised decision rights?

03 • Implementation coach: Start with the observed behavior. The guide hasn't been explained, so motivation would be an unsupported inference.

04 • Client change lead: I'll ask the manager to describe which step was unclear and what source they were using.

05 • Implementation coach: Good. Then compare the routes using a concrete case and explain who owns each decision.

06 • Client change lead: Could we repeat the practice after the explanation to see whether the new route is clearer?

07 • Implementation coach: Yes. That provides actionable feedback and a chance to demonstrate understanding without claiming permanent adoption.

08 • Client change lead: I'll avoid calling the operating model embedded based on one successful rehearsal.

09 • Implementation coach: Exactly. Practice supports readiness; actual use and continued monitoring answer a different question.

10 • Client change lead: We'll agree that follow-up and use any remaining confusion to improve the implementation support.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A change champion answers every question

Separate fictional case: during a new-process workshop, the change champion answers every case question before the other managers can respond. The coach gives feedback directly between practice rounds.

01 • Implementation coach: You answered each case question before the other managers had a chance to respond in that round.

02 • Change champion: I wanted to keep the session moving. I thought giving the right answer would help everyone learn.

03 • Implementation coach: Your knowledge helps, but that pattern prevents us from seeing whether the other managers can apply the operating model.

04 • Change champion: So a correct answer from me can hide uncertainty about their decision rights?

05 • Implementation coach: Exactly. In the next round, please pause and let the named manager explain their next step first.

06 • Change champion: What should I do if their answer misses an approval responsibility?

07 • Implementation coach: Let them finish. Then ask a clarifying question or offer a correction when invited, using the agreed guide.

08 • Change champion: I will wait for their explanation and support it afterward rather than answer on their behalf.

09 • Implementation coach: Good. I will watch whether more managers demonstrate the process, not just whether we finish quickly.

10 • Change champion: Understood. I will pause in the next round and help clarify after they have responded.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Implementation and Change Management

Managers are expected to adopt a new process but have not received training or time to practice.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Second round: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Model for scenario 1: The rollout asks managers to change their work without enough preparation. Could we add role-specific training and a short practice period, then check where adoption is difficult?

Scenario 2 | A checklist completed from memory

In a fictional practice session, a manager marks every new-process step complete without consulting the case evidence. Two steps have no supporting information. Give specific coaching feedback and agree another practice round.

Role A: You are the implementation coach. Describe the unsupported completion marks and their effect on process reliability.

Role B: You are the client manager who completed the checklist. Explain your approach, respond to the evidence gap, and agree how you will check each step in another practice round.

Possible opening: Two steps were marked complete without supporting information, so the checklist doesn't yet demonstrate correct process use.

Success checks

- Distinguish form completion from correct process use.
- Give and respond to behavior-specific feedback without guessing motives.
- Agree a practical evidence-based rehearsal and follow-up check.

Add a complication: The manager says completing the form quickly proves adoption.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The steering group has not selected an option

Separate fictional extension of the lesson: the steering group agrees that service handovers need improvement but is split between a one-branch pilot and a full rollout. Operations worries about untested training; the sponsor worries that a pilot delays wider benefits. Decision authority is unconfirmed and two minutes remain.

01 • Steering facilitator: We agree handovers need improvement, but not whether to pilot at one branch or roll out fully. Operations, what is your main concern?

02 • Operations director: Training is untested. I favor a one-branch pilot so we can observe how managers use the process.

03 • Steering facilitator: Sponsor, which concern makes you favor the full rollout?

04 • Client sponsor: A pilot delays wider benefits. I want the whole service to improve sooner.

05 • Steering facilitator: Then the disagreement concerns rollout pace and readiness, not the need for improvement. Who can authorize this choice?

06 • Client sponsor: That authority still needs confirmation. I will identify the decision owner and the required next step.

07 • Steering facilitator: Operations, can you provide the outstanding training questions for that decision discussion?

08 • Operations director: Yes. I will identify what remains untested without treating the pilot as already approved.

09 • Steering facilitator: We agree on the problem; both options remain open. The sponsor confirms decision authority, and operations supplies the training questions.

10 • Client sponsor: That summary is accurate. No rollout option was approved today, and I own confirming the next decision step.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

The absent operations voice

Separate fictional case: a steering committee discusses a proposed rollout while the operations representative is absent; operational resource requirements have not been confirmed.

01 • Engagement director: The operations representative is absent, and the rollout's resource requirements remain unconfirmed. We need to keep that gap visible.

02 • Committee chair: Can the rest of us approve the option and assume operations will resolve the staffing afterward?

03 • Engagement director: That depends on your decision authority, but we shouldn't present an unconfirmed resource assumption as an agreed fact.

04 • Committee chair: Then let's distinguish any decision we can make from the operational confirmation still needed.

05 • Engagement director: Yes. Could you identify who will obtain the operations view and how it returns to the decision process?

06 • Committee chair: I'll ask the operations lead to respond and confirm the appropriate route for reviewing any resulting constraint.

07 • Engagement director: Good. The readout should include that action and any conditions attached to the committee's actual decision.

08 • Committee chair: Please don't list the absent representative as supportive simply because no objection was recorded.

09 • Engagement director: Agreed. I'll summarize only expressed views and the unresolved resource question.

10 • Committee chair: Let's read that back now so the committee confirms the record before we close.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A risk discussion needs a decision owner

Separate fictional case: a final readout presents a pilot with an unresolved supplier dependency; attendees discuss the risk but nobody identifies who can accept it.

01 • Readout facilitator: We've discussed the supplier dependency, but who has authority to decide whether the pilot proceeds with that risk?

02 • Client program sponsor: The delivery team can explain the dependency, but I need to confirm the decision owner.

03 • Readout facilitator: Then let's separate providing evidence from accepting risk. Those responsibilities may belong to different people.

04 • Client program sponsor: Agreed. Can we hear the delivery lead's remaining concern before defining the next step?

05 • Readout facilitator: Yes. I'll invite that view and keep the option set open until the decision process is clear.

06 • Client program sponsor: We shouldn't let the final presentation title imply that the pilot has already been authorized.

07 • Readout facilitator: Exactly. The final readout can conclude the analysis while a client decision remains outstanding.

08 • Client program sponsor: I'll identify the authorized decision owner and confirm how the supplier question should be escalated.

09 • Readout facilitator: I'll record that responsibility and read back the unresolved dependency, without assigning an invented acceptance deadline.

10 • Client program sponsor: Good. That gives the group a concrete next step instead of leaving a long discussion with no owner.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Steering Committees and Final Readouts

A steering group agrees on the problem but is split between two options. The presentation time is almost over.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: Let's pause the slides and compare the two options against the agreed criteria. Then we can record the decision, or the precise unresolved question and who will resolve it by when.

Scenario 2 | A vote is suggested without an agreed process

A fictional steering discussion is divided between a small pilot and a wider rollout. A participant suggests an immediate show of hands, but the committee's decision method has not been confirmed. Facilitate a clear next process step.

Role A: You are the facilitator. Summarize both options and ask how the decision should be made.

Role B: You are the client sponsor. Accept responsibility for confirming the committee's decision process.

Possible opening: Before using a show of hands, could we confirm how this committee is authorized to decide?

Success checks

- Distinguish expressed support from a valid recorded decision.
- Preserve both options and the main unresolved concern.
- Assign confirmation of the decision process before claiming approval.

Add a complication: A participant interprets the louder support for rollout as formal approval.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Consulting English

Professional audience: management consultants, strategy consultants, implementation consultants, analysts, engagement managers, client partners, internal consultants, and advisory teams

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Dialogue 01: Discovery discussion

Original fictional setting: Consultants clarify a client's initial problem statement.

Professional roles: Engagement manager / Client operations director

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

Engagement manager: You described the problem as low productivity. Where does it show up in the workflow?

Client operations director: Orders wait between review and approval, but staff utilization looks high.

Engagement manager: Then we should examine queue time and rework, not assume people need to work faster.

Client operations director: We can provide process records and introduce the approval teams.

Engagement manager: I'll frame the diagnostic questions and agree on the scope of the first analysis.

Client operations director: Please distinguish what you know from the hypotheses you're testing in the kickoff materials.

Vocabulary in this exchange: scope: Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Interactive workplace role-play

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.
2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.
3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.
4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.
5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Create more scenario dialogues

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

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Engagement manager: I'll frame the diagnostic questions and agree on the scope of the first analysis.

Client operations director: Please distinguish what you know from the hypotheses you're testing in the kickoff materials.

Vocabulary in this exchange: scope: Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.
2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.
3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.
4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.
5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level